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Teen And Up Audiences

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The Ghost of You (Never Coming Home)

by Zyperis

Summary

"Hiding your feelings from someone you love is like dying alive"

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

“Adora, get down!” Those are the last words Adora hears before she’s shoved violently to the ground- landing hard and sprawling out on her back. Her eyes barely focus in time to gaze up through the smoke filled air towards an unfairly blue sky and watch as Catra stands over her- rifle held firmly in her hands, heterochromatic gaze trained down the length of the barrel as she shoots over Adora’s prone form. Round after round launched- spewing hot brass casings, dusting Catra’s freckles over with gunpowder residue, as she engages the enemy trying to overwhelm their position. Green camouflage never suited her or her style, but she looks good in anything and when they’re casually relaxing back at base camp- Adora spends hours secretly staring. Now, especially, Catra looks stunning- the gleam of the sun overhead highlighting every perfect feature she has and the fierce look on her face only makes her more beautiful.

It would be the perfect image if they weren’t in the middle of the war, if they weren’t actively fighting for their lives, if Catra hadn’t shoved her down onto the ground to engage whatever threat she saw before Adora did. Catra’s the best marksman in the whole platoon- she has a near perfect record and Adora has never seen her miss a single shot. She’s earned medals for it- medals Adora’s both proud of her for and secretly jealous of, but watching Catra fire her rifle rapidly- the short sweeping motions as she changes targets time and again without ever looking down to taunt Adora with that *smirk* as she hits her mark- Adora knows it’s bad. Adora knows Catra isn’t missing. She knows that every single time Catra pulls the trigger in combat someone else on the wrong side of the war is dying, but even with the glint of dozens of brass casings flying through the air- Catra isn’t stopping.

Everything in war happens too fast and before Adora has had so much as a moment to move or so much as think about moving to help engage the enemy she watches as Catra’s body recoils from more than the impact of her own rifle. The red mist of blood sprays out from behind her and the force of the impacts twists her around as she falls and Adora doesn’t move in time to even catch her. It seems impossible- Catra always comes out unscathed

without any serious injury to speak of. Cuts, scrapes, bruises, the occasional burn- they had both been treated by a medic while joking together as they got patched up, but never had they become a casualty. They were too good for that, they watched out for each other even more so than everyone else, they fought together and-

"Catra!" Adora screams, twisting herself around to lunge toward where her best friend fell- leaving her own rifle behind like a failure. Catra is on her back, right shoulder already soaked in red as her blood quickly turns the dirt to mud. "Medic!" Adora screams- willing her voice to be heard over the chorus of gunfire and explosions and screams going off all around her. Nothing else matters though- the world was ending as long as Catra is wounded and Adora's whole world zeroes down to her best friend. Kneeling over her, Adora begins reaching for her own gear, with enough pressure and something to stop the bleeding, maybe she could-

Catra's left hand seizes the neck of her shirt and yanks her aside, so that Adora falls forward- half on top of her very best friend. Before Adora can react, the bang of a gun being discharged right by her ear turns her world to white and sends her cringing- seeking safety by flinching closer still to Catra. She *feels* a second, third, and fourth shot ring out- deafening her entirely and disorienting her almost beyond reason, but when Adora manages to open her eyes she sees Catra staring past her, pistol held in her outstretched right hand before it drops heavy and limp by her side. Catra's eyes swing over to her own then and although all Adora can hear is the silent ringing in the aftermath of nearly having her eardrums blown out, she can still read the affectionate words Catra says with a smile: *fucking idiot*.

But then Catra's head falls back- her beautiful heterochromatic eyes leaving Adora's own, her mouth goes slack- causing her signature beautiful smirk to disappear, and Adora remembers the *blood*, remembers *where they are*, and realizes *exactly* what just happened. Whirling around, Adora sees the frightening reality- three dead bodies dressed in the uniforms of the enemy- having

managed to cross the perimeter they were supposed to be holding. Catra stopped them- she was lying bleeding on the ground and she had to shoot them because Adora couldn't do her job or help at all. Turning back to Catra, Adora's already fumbling with her gear- shaky hands and nerves making her completely useless and that's when she *really* sees it. It's not just Catra's right shoulder soaked in blood- it's her whole chest so that the green camouflage is lost entirely to the bloody sea welling up from within Catra.

Adora screams wildly, shoving her hands against Catra's chest as if she could ever staunch the flow of that much blood- of that many wounds. Catra doesn't react to her scream or the pressure- her eyes are already glassy as they stare up at the sky and Adora *knows*, but she can't and won't accept it. The medic comes, probably because of her hysterical screaming, but it takes hardly a second for him to confirm Adora's worst fears and pressing her own blood soaked hand against Catra's neck doesn't bring even the faintest sensation of a pulse. The world was ending. It's the only thought in Adora's mind with the battle raging so far away because nothing matters any more- not without Catra. She couldn't possibly leave Catra's side, but if she doesn't and more enemies come and they kill her when Catra had saved her life…

Adora doesn't know why she's moving. She lurches backward with sobs stuck in her throat and tears in her eyes and she reclaims her rifle that she stupidly left behind with single minded determination. She rises up over the barricades and finally takes in the scene that caused Catra to act. The enemy is charging- in numbers too great to stop. They aren't supposed to be getting attacked, their reinforcements aren't supposed to be delayed, the rebels aren't supposed to be this well equipped, Catra isn't supposed to be dead. Shouldering her rifle, Adora begins firing off rounds with a desperation she never felt before. She isn't shooting for evaluation, she isn't shooting skeet for fun, she isn't trying to outdo her best friend, she isn't even trying to save her own life or hold her position like a good solider- she only knows pain and needs to avenge Catra as if that would ever fix anything. But she

can’t stay kneeling over her friend’s corpse- watching her eyes grow cloudy and let her death mean nothing, so she fights.

It’s a battle trance the likes of which Adora has never known. She always has trouble counting her shots, she always needs more than one to drop her target. She always gets tunnel vision. But not now. It’s like she knows where the enemy is going to be before they do and she knows every round she fires off will hit without needing to see evidence of it. There are entirely too many rebels to stop, but Adora doesn’t care. There isn’t anything left in this world to care about. Not anymore. Catra hadn’t even wanted to join the military- that was Adora’s dream. Adora had told her not to enlist, but Catra *laughed* while saying, *if I don’t sign up with you, who else will make sure you come home alive, Stupid? Face it- you need me*. Adora still needs her- more than air or water or an extra magazine when she runs out of ammo. They’re supposed to hold this position at all costs, but the cost has already been entirely too high- a price Adora would never pay for anything. A retreat should have been called, but it isn’t and Adora kills her way to a victory- standing alone as she uses everything within reach as a weapon all while the memories swirl in her head because that’s all that’s left. She’s never going to hear Catra’s voice or laugh again- her last words drowning Adora in anguish and grief until she loses herself completely.

Most soldiers are being buried in mass graves- the dead too numerous to count, so almost no consideration is given to ship the bodies home for a proper burial. Exceptions can be made- for the right price, but money isn’t something Adora cares about. She and Catra had dreams of renting an apartment together- a nice one close to downtown. That dream died with Catra. It costs several months’ of pay to have Catra’s body shipped home, nearly a year’s worth to get her a headstone and a proper burial, and her next several months of pay are forfeit so that the adjacent plot can remain empty for Adora herself. The money doesn’t matter. Catra’s not here to buy gifts for and Adora doesn’t want souvenirs. The only memories of value are all of her best friend. But giving Catra a proper burial is the only thing she can do.

She should count herself lucky. Adora knows she's getting more consideration and privilege than most soldiers would. It's a consequence of the promotion she earned and the medals they awarded her for bravery and valor. But the medals are pointless- cold and lifeless like Catra and Adora wishes she didn't have them. People look at her and marvel as the rumors spread- of how she held the line against insurmountable odds. Adora doesn't remember the battle or how it ends. She remembers only the end of the world and her life ending that day. Weeks and months pass and her body moves, but her thoughts and her mind are already home- silently waiting in the dark of a grave as if she'll ever make it back to her. She won't make it back to her side. Catra didn't believe in an afterlife- always smirking as she lamented having to tolerate this one. Adora would remake the next world just for her if she got to have Catra back beside her. She won't.

Unofficially, it's a suicide mission. Officially, it's the operation that could see the end of the war with their victory secured. At least this time, Adora doesn't have to volunteer- they approach her- *request* her since she successfully completed the last four suicide missions she volunteered for. She isn't trying to kill herself. She promises all the therapists she talks to. She just wants to do her duty, she wants to fight for her country, she wants the honor of accomplishing the mission, and if she can save her comrades' lives and prevent them from dying in her stead if necessary- she wants to take that chance because she believes they'd do the same for her. She's lying. Her dead eyes should make that clear to anyone who cares, but even as bad an actor as she is- she fools them.

Honestly, it sounds like a victory to her either way. Either she accomplishes the mission against all odds- avenging Catra and proving her sacrifice was worth something or she dies and at least finds an end to the pain. She doesn't die. She's convinced she can't. The bullets always miss her or otherwise leave her with nothing more than a minor flesh wound and she kills with a ruthless precision that many find terrifying. Some say she has a guardian angel. She did. And now she's dead and Adora is all that's left.

When the war ends after she delivers on every objective set before her- she's lauded in praise, decorated in medals, commended by the highest authorities. It's everything she could have ever wished for and it's all meaningless without Catra by her side. Some take her stoic nature as a sign of strict duty- of a humble soldier who exemplifies the notion that she only did what any soldier as capable as her would do. The truth is she doesn't care anymore. She's not signing up for another term of service and she's not even counting the days until she gets to go home. All she keeps waiting for is the nightmare to end, but it never does. Catra's dead and she's not coming back- no matter what Adora wishes, dreams, or prays for.

Returning home isn't returning home. The roof over her head, the place she can be alone, the air and the walls all echo with the absence in her heart. Catra was her home. Maybe she still is. Life is empty without her and everything hurts. The void in her chest sucks up the entire world until it's all black and desolate. Adora doesn't visit the grave. She can't. Catra hated silence and Adora doesn't have anything to say. The words don't exist to express her sorrow, her love, her regret, and she doesn't deserve forgiveness- not that Catra would think she needs to be forgiven. But Catra isn't here and she certainly isn't in that grave because no matter where her body is buried she isn't *here* and it should be Adora instead because the pain of being alive is too much to bear.

Suicide would be tempting if she wouldn't be throwing away the very thing Catra died to protect. At least in war- her dying might not have been her fault. Now she has to live with the guilt forever.

They end up giving her a package of all of Catra's belongings- apparently she left a will and left everything to Adora. There's not much to go through. It makes sense- Catra never had much. Neither of them did. But they had each other. *Had* each other. Whatever Adora has now feels like nothing at all. Not without her.

Adora opens the package anyway- it's all she has left. Money, clothes, pictures, dog tags. All of it fits inside a box far too small

to ever contain all that Catra is and was, but the world was too small for that. Nestled in at the top of the box is the only item Adora doesn't recognize- a tape recorder. She doesn't touch any of it- all of it sits too heavy in her hands to hold or touch. She stares at it, for hours every day for weeks, unable to move it and unable to touch it. Truthfully, she feels unable to even eat or sleep or breathe, but somehow her body manages all of that for her.

It's the tape recorder that draws her back- something Adora didn't know Catra possessed and considering she knew *everything* about her best friend… it seems at once like an invasion- a defilement of Catra's well guarded secrets, but also like the only piece of her that might be left. What could Catra possibly have bothered to record? It certainly wasn't music, or their stupid late night banter, and Adora knew Catra didn't record her thoughts- sly jabs of *narcissistic much?* would no doubt be leveraged against anyone Catra found doing something like that. Adora lies to herself and says it's because of curiosity that she decides to play the recording and not one foolish pointless hope that she might hear her best friend's voice captured in the background audio.

"Hey, Adora," Catra's voice comes through bright and clear- happy and seductive all at once with that sexy raspy voice she has. Had. Because she's gone. Even as it's more than Adora hoped for- this is already too hard. Hearing Catra's voice, knowing she left this *for* Adora herself. She can't bear to hear it and yet can't bring herself to turn it off. "We just got our orders to head to the front, so I'm recording this in case something happens. Of course, that makes it sound like some fatalistic self-determining prophecy bullshit, but… if something *does* happen and I don't do this… I want you to have closure. If you're actually listening to this, then I'm dead and if I know you- you're probably blaming yourself even though *it's not your fault*. Honestly, it's probably mine, and if it is my fault, you probably want to know why and the truth is I love you. Wow, that was a lot easier to say than I thought." Catra laughs aloud on the recording and it's the most beautiful sound- so full and bright that Adora can't help but break down entirely into tears- still gripped by every word Catra says. And yet, somehow, as beautiful as Catra's laugh is and although Adora would have given anything

to hear it just one more time- not even her beautiful laugh can compare to the way her words ring in Adora's head. *I love you*. How many times had Adora mouthed those same words- unable to even dare to whisper them in the dark as she lay awake while looking at her best friend, only for Catra to visit her in her dreams because the two of them were inseperable… *were* inspeperable because they aren't together now and Adora can only regret that the fear of losing her friend stopped her from sharing her own love confession because Adora lost her anyway and she isn't afraid of anything now- not anymore, and hearing Catra tell her *now* that she's loved ensures that the air will never return to her lungs and the tears will never stop because she's lost everything. "But it's true. I love you, Adora. I always have. I'd kill for you and die for you, so honestly, joining up for the war seems pretty on theme. Besides, you're a fucking idiot and if I'm not there to watch your back- who else is going to keep you from getting yourself killed? I know you're going to be some great war hero and save the whole damn world, but that's why I'm tagging along- to save you from yourself. And if you're listening to this and I'm not sitting right there- embarrassed and trying to delete this shit, then I want you to move on. I love you, Stupid, so all I want is for you to be happy- I'd give anything to see that dumb grin on your face. So go- move on, find a new best friend- as if you could replace me- and find love with someone who will tell you to your face that you're loved. Anyway, I'm being dramatic- I'll delete this when we make it home. I can hear you coming anyway. And by the way," Catra whispered the words into the recorder, "I'm giving you your first kiss tonight in your sleep and I fully intend on getting more if you end up choosing to love me too." Adora already loves her- there's no choice to make, it was- *is*- always going to be Catra. She could so easily see the sly smirk on Catra's face, the way she'd bite her bottom lip with one canine tooth poking out, those brilliant eyes gleaming vibrantly with allure and mischief. Adora would give anything to hang on to that moment- her *love* for just one second more. "Goodbye, Adora."

The councilors she talks to all tell her the same thing- she has survivor's guilt and PTSD. They say that she'll learn to manage the

pain, that things will get easier in time, that eventually life will go back to normal and she'll move on- grateful with the closure she has. But Adora knows the truth. Her heart died on hill 143 at 11:06 am- lost in the gaze of cyan and amber eyes of the most amazing girl Adora will ever know- the true war hero whose name no one knows and who made the world worth living in. And it would never beat again.

Fin.

End Notes

Sometimes I just need to have my heart torn out. I had intended this story to be hurt/comfort and have a happy ending, but it clearly had other ideas. Still, this narrative satisfied the burst of inspiration and desire I had to read a fic of a similar nature to this and I'm quite proud of the end result. As always, I thank you very much for reading and I hope you "enjoyed" this work as much as possible, given the subject matter.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!